

Johnson deserves better

JOHNSON/BURGEE: ARCHITECTURE

By Nory Miller; photographs by
Richard Payne. Random House. 118
pp. \$35.

By Robert Campbell

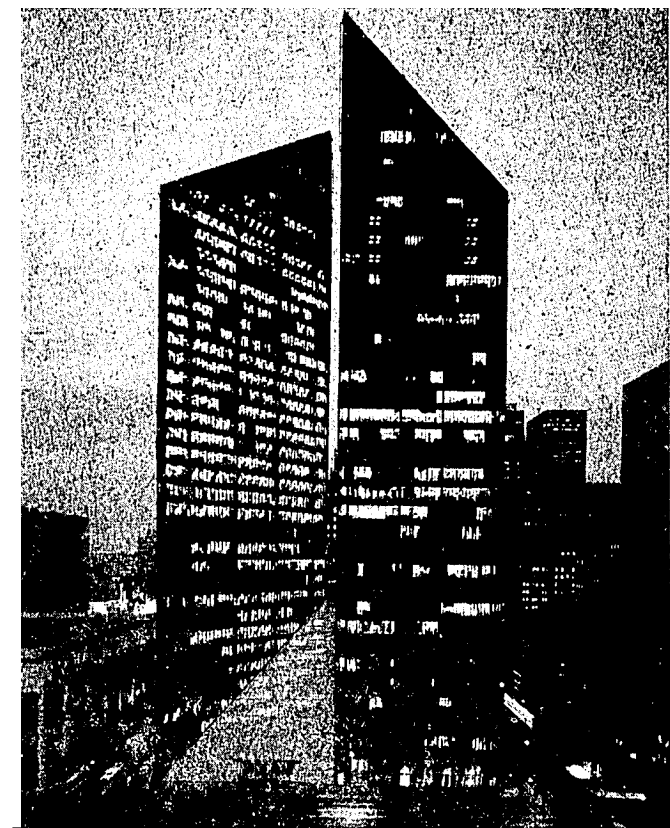
This isn't a book, it's an overblown office brochure.

The tip-off is the typography. Imitated, apparently, from some perfume advertisement, it's wire-thin, curvy, cunningly elegant, and almost impossible to read.

Unreadability is no drawback in this case, though. Author Nory Miller, a good writer who shouldn't have let herself get involved in this project, offers absolutely nothing but praise for each and every detail of these 21 buildings designed by the firm of Johnson/Burgee.

Philip Johnson deserves better than this. You can like his work or hate it (or, what would bother him more, not care), but you can't settle for this lurid panegyric.

Johnson is the most mercurial architect in American history. He started out in the '30s as a founder of the Museum of Modern Art and an early advocate of architectural modernism. Later he became an architect himself and rebelled repeatedly against modernism. In the '50s he did prettified candy-box classicism. Then came a series of big angled shapes, influenced by minimalist sculpture, such as *Pennzoil Place in Houston*. Most recently there have been theatrical buildings that loosely imitate or parody the past, such as the A T & T tower in New York (Renaissance) or the Pittsburgh Plate Glass



Night view of Pennzoil Place, Houston, Tex.

headquarters in Pittsburgh (House of Parliament Gothic). These have propelled Johnson onto the cover of *Time* and into the status of celebrity. His partnership with the younger John Burgee dates from the '60s.

Ever-changing, Johnson in his work has often been seminal but at other times shallow, pompous or crowd-pleasing. He is brilliant, funny, cynical, iconoclastic, pragmatic. His career deserves a real book but this isn't it.

There's enough here to embarrass just about everyone. For your \$35 you get con-

tinual bad grammar, misdirected metaphors and verbal slop like "trancept" for transept and "homogenation" for, I guess, homogenization. Even the photographs by Richard Payne, which are technically marvelous, too often belong to the school that views the building as merely the means to a striking, semi-abstract photographic composition, instead of regarding the photograph as an honest representation of the building at its best. Still, the photography is by far the best thing in this book. All the rest is flak.

Robert Campbell is a Cambridge architect and *The Globe's* architecture critic.